

**Berkeley Neighbors for Housing & Climate Action
2024 Candidate Questionnaire**

Candidate Name: Deborah Matthews

District / Office being sought: Council Member, District 3

1. Berkeley's Housing Element lays out the city's plan for new housing construction through 2031, ensuring the city can meet its Regional Housing Needs Allocation (RHNA) of ~9,000 homes across a range of income levels.

The Housing Element commits Berkeley to a number of major policy changes in order to meet state requirements for affirmatively furthering fair housing, including citywide zoning for "missing middle" housing, a San Pablo Specific Plan, an updated Demolition Ordinance, and upzoning along North Shattuck, Solano, and College Ave, among other items.

What is your view on the Housing Element and these policies? What are the most important things we need to do to implement the City's Housing Element?

Please discuss your ideas and priorities around:

- a. Missing Middle Housing
- b. San Pablo specific plan
- c. Zoning for housing in high-resource neighborhoods like North Shattuck, Solano, and College Ave

Response to Q1:

Summary Response: I strongly support the Housing Element. The most important task is to build more low and missing middle housing, especially infill properties and ADUs (accessory dwelling units).

Missing middle housing – As most recently proposed by the Council, the Missing Middle Housing Ordinance will provide critical zoning changes to increase density throughout the city, which I strongly support. I suggest expanding our efforts to a fairness and equity lens, which includes an analysis of unintended consequences for low-income, at-risk, and long-term property owners who have historically been denied fair home market value and wealth building due to racist zoning, covenants, redlining, and eminent domain. This lens will ensure our policies embrace all communities and eliminate unforeseen inequities.

San Pablo Ave. Specific Plan—The process to revise and update the San Pablo Avenue Specific Plan has just begun, primarily to increase housing in that area. As identified in the Housing Element, 20% of the City of Berkeley’s opportunity sites are located in this planning area. A revised plan is critical to meeting our housing goals, making the area more pedestrian-friendly, and continuing the existing San Pablo Corridor Transit Plan.

Zoning in high-resource neighborhoods – The proposed Missing Middle Ordinance will remove the single-family zoning designation and up-zone all of these high-resource neighborhoods. This Ordinance is critical to Berkeley’s ability to provide Missing Middle Housing.

2. Berkeley’s Climate Action Plan sets forth a goal of 80% reduction in greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions by 2050. Today, the two major sources of GHG emissions in Berkeley are from gas-powered automobiles and natural gas used in buildings.

Berkeley has a variety of plans and programs intended to help address these emissions, including the Electric Mobility Roadmap and the Berkeley Existing Building Electrification Strategy. Other related efforts include the Bicycle Plan and Pedestrian Master Plan, as well as the City’s now-defunct natural gas ban on new buildings. Upcoming policy initiatives include the Berkeley Building Electrification and Just Transition Pilot Program, Measure GG, the Bay Area Air Quality Management District’s regional ban on new NOx-emitting appliances, and more.

What is your view on the Climate Action Plan and these strategies? What are the most important things we need to do to address greenhouse gas emissions?

Please discuss your ideas and priorities around how Berkeley can reduce emissions from transportation and buildings, and how we should align the climate transition with our other goals as a city.

Response to Q2:

All the efforts mentioned in the question above are needed because they address problems from different perspectives. Timely implementation is critical to achieving our goals by 2050. I am particularly focused on the Electric Mobility Road Map (adopted in 2006), especially for District 3. Neighbors don’t feel safe leaving their homes, answering a knock on the door, or walking to a local store. Drug activity interferes with small businesses; shootings occur in the middle of the day. We need improved safety before many residents can walk around the neighborhood again. The Electric Mobility Road Map focuses on improved equity by making the area safe and comfortable for all pedestrians.

3. In your opinion, what was the most important City Council vote on Berkeley's housing crisis in the past four years? Briefly describe the issue, what you think of the Council's decision, and what you would have done had you been on the Council. For incumbents, please describe why you voted the way you did, and what you think now about that vote.

Response to Q3:

Berkeley has strengthened its inclusionary housing requirements, which provide opportunities for increased fairness and equity in housing citywide. To help ensure the construction of more homes, Berkeley also adopted new zoning rules that allow ADUs by right citywide. ADU rents tend to be at below-market-rate levels; their turnover rates are low; they allow low-income homeowners to stay in the neighborhoods; they support extended family care; and they provide tenants with a comfortable living environment. ADUs are the least expensive and fastest housing to build and provide the opportunity for all property owners to participate in the housing solution.

4. In your opinion, what was the most important climate or environmental issue faced by the Berkeley City Council in the last four years? Briefly describe the issue, what you think of the Council's decision, and what you would have done had you been on the Council. For incumbents, please describe why you voted the way you did, and what you think now about that vote.

Response to Q4:

Climate issues are interconnected and complicated; issues and their interrelationships frequently change. To meet this challenge, Berkeley needs to adopt a 30-year planning process to successfully develop, fund, and implement the best climate solutions. The Vision 2050 Plan was created over 2 years by extensive community engagement and efforts of staff, volunteers, consultants, the Council, and the Mayor. It provided concrete proposals to encourage collaborative, long-term decision-making and funding. We should reconsider the recommendations in the Vision 2050 Plan that could be beneficial to us now.

5. To achieve its RHNA goals, Berkeley must continue to build homes for all income levels. These new residents will need to travel within Berkeley. Greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions from transportation comprise roughly 60% of total emissions in Berkeley.

How would you ensure that Berkeley continues to reduce GHG emissions while adding new homes?

Response to Q5:

The current building code includes strong construction standards to conserve energy and reduce GHG emissions. Other options, such as moving homes from gas to Fossil Free Fuel, may discourage housing construction by increasing housing costs. If adopted, it should be phased in with sensitivity to all income levels and to increased construction costs. Significant reductions may be more easily attained by providing easy access to reliable transit, cycling, and walking as alternatives to driving. We should continue to explore opportunities of shared-mobility options, such as city shuttle service, to reduce traffic, congestion, and the need for parking.

6. Walking and biking present opportunities to help Berkeley residents reduce their GHG emissions, but safety concerns can be a major deterrent. Of the two competing street paving measures on the ballot this November, one of the major differences between the two is the approach to funding safety improvements for walking and biking.

Measure EE would provide safety funding only for traffic calming on bicycle boulevards and major pedestrian projects identified in the Pedestrian Plan. Measure FF would provide funding to implement safety measures throughout the city, based on existing plans.

What is your perspective on how we should address pedestrian and cyclists' safety on our streets? What is your perspective on these two measures?

Response to Q6:

Both measures require careful consideration. Measure FF will provide more revenue and better-targeted outcomes to help ensure cyclists' safety and improve pedestrian access. However, neither measure provides sufficient revenue to improve our sidewalks and streets to an acceptable standard, even when combined with COB's annual \$19m/year contribution.

7. Berkeley has a long history of using zoning, restrictive covenants and redlining to achieve racial and economic segregation. This history continues to shape Berkeley today.

Recent research by the Turner Center at UC Berkeley suggests that inclusionary zoning requirements, which mandate on-site restricted affordable housing in new developments, may have the effect of reducing overall housing construction, including the production of affordable units. However, on-site affordable housing can also be an effective tool for desegregating neighborhood

What is your perspective on how Berkeley should use inclusionary zoning requirements, versus other affordable housing development options (such as in-lieu fees)?

Response to Q7:

The in-lieu fees, available through the Housing Trust Fund, have historically been the most effective way to provide Affordable Housing. Additionally, these funds could create programs that provide low-income property owners with opportunities to participate in expanding the housing supply, securing their futures, and building wealth.

8. Many of the highest income neighborhoods in Berkeley are also in the Hillside Overlay, portions of which are in the California Very High Fire Hazard Severity Zone (CalFire VHFHSZ). How should we balance fire risk with affirmatively furthering fair housing?

Response to Q8:

New construction is significantly more fire resistant than older homes; thus, allowing ADU and duplex construction and replacing/redeveloping existing homes will lower fire risk. Due to the steep terrain, there is less buildable space for new construction. High fire risk and the lack of buildable space mean we can expect a limited increase in population and cars in the Hillside communities. The current Berkeley Fire Department Defensible Space Protection program/actions to enforce vegetation rules and improve evacuation routes will enhance safety for all residents.